Harry Potter and the Clockwork Guardian

An original fan-fiction story

Chapter 1: The Brass Owl

It rained on Hogwarts all that October week, a steady grey rain that drummed on the tower windows and turned the grounds to mud. Harry Potter sat in the Gryffindor common room with a half-finished Potions essay, watching the fire and not really thinking about Potions at all.

Something tapped at the window.

Harry expected a school owl, but what hovered outside was not feathered. It was made of brass, no bigger than a teapot, with tiny cogs turning behind its glass eyes. Its wings clicked softly as it beat them against the rain. Harry opened the window and the little owl hopped onto his desk, dripping.

"Is that a clockwork owl?" Hermione Granger had appeared at his shoulder, her book forgotten. "Harry, those haven't been made in two hundred years."

"It's not carrying a letter," said Ron Weasley, peering over the other side. He was right. Instead, a small copper tag hung from one of its talons. Harry turned it over. Scratched into the metal, in thin, careful writing, were the words: *Third floor. Behind the sleeping portrait. Midnight. Come only if you are curious.*

The owl gave one final whirr, folded its wings, and went completely still, as though its spring had run down.

The three friends looked at each other. Ron grinned. Hermione frowned, though not very convincingly.

"It could be a trap," she said.

"It could," agreed Harry, already reaching for his Invisibility Cloak.

Chapter 2: The Sleeping Portrait

At a quarter to midnight the castle was silent except for the groan of old timbers and the distant snoring of the paintings. Harry, Ron, and Hermione crept beneath the Cloak, which was getting rather too small for three, and every few steps someone's foot poked out and had to be tucked back in.

"Mind the fourth step," whispered Harry. "It vanishes."

"I know," Hermione whispered back. "I read about it."

On the third floor, the corridor was dark and smelled faintly of candle wax and damp stone. Halfway along hung a large portrait that Harry had walked past a hundred times without noticing. It showed a plump old wizard in a nightcap, slumped in an armchair, fast asleep, his mouth open.

"That's Sir Cornelius Drowse," said Hermione. "He's been asleep in that frame since the sixteen hundreds. Nobody knows why."

Harry pulled off the Cloak and held up the copper tag. The moment it came near the portrait, the painted wizard gave a tremendous snore, and the tag grew warm in Harry's hand.

"Er," said Harry. "Hello? We were told to come."

One of Sir Cornelius's eyes opened, a bright and rather clever blue. "Curious, are you?" he murmured. "Good. The dull ones never find the door."

The whole portrait swung outward like a cupboard, and behind it was a narrow stone staircase winding down into the dark.

Chapter 3: The Hidden Workshop

The staircase went down much farther than it should have. Ron counted a hundred and twelve steps before he lost track. At the bottom was a round room lit by hundreds of floating lamps, each one a tiny glass bulb with a warm golden flame inside.

Harry stopped in the doorway and simply stared.

The room was a workshop. Long wooden benches ran around the walls, crowded with half-built contraptions: a mechanical dragonfly with wings of silver foil, a music box that played its tune backwards, a small brass cat that arched its back and purred like a kettle. Hundreds of clockwork creatures stood on shelves, quite motionless, covered in a fine layer of dust.

"Who made all of this?" breathed Hermione, running a finger along a workbench.

"I did," said a voice, "a very long time ago."

A figure stepped out from behind a tall cabinet. She was a witch with silver hair twisted into a bun, spectacles pushed up on her forehead, and sleeves rolled to the elbow. Her hands were stained black with oil.

"Professor Ottoline Brightwater," she said, with a brisk nod. "I taught Charms here, centuries ago, before the school forgot me. Sit down, all of you. You will want to sit down."

They found three stools. Ron accidentally knocked over a tin bird, which hopped away across the floor and hid under a bench.

"I sent the owl," said Professor Brightwater, "because I need help. Something in this castle is waking up, and I am too old to stop it alone."

Chapter 4: The Problem with Clockwork

"Every creature in this room," said Professor Brightwater, "runs on a spell I invented called the Living Spring. It does not wind down. It keeps a little spark of thought turning inside the gears, just enough to let them hop and flutter and sing."

"That's brilliant," said Hermione, truly impressed.

"It was," said the old witch sadly. "Until I made the largest one."

She led them to the far end of the workshop. There, under a great grey sheet, stood something enormous. Harry could make out a shape taller than the Hogwarts gamekeeper, with broad shoulders and a heavy iron head.

"I called him the Guardian," she said. "I built him to patrol the castle at night and keep students out of danger. But the spring I gave him was too strong. He began to think. And then he began to worry. Poor thing, he worried about everyone, every second, all at once. One night he simply walked into the walls of Hogwarts and became part of them. I have not seen him since."

Ron swallowed. "Part of the walls? Like, inside them?"

"Quite so. And tonight, for the first time in three hundred years, I can hear him ticking again."

As if in answer, a deep, slow thud echoed through the stone above their heads. Then another. The lamps shivered. Dust drifted down from the ceiling and settled in Hermione's hair.

"Something tells me," said Harry quietly, "that we have about ten minutes."

Chapter 5: The Ticking in the Walls

They climbed the hundred and twelve steps so fast that Ron got a stitch. Back in the third-floor corridor, the ticking was louder now, a heavy iron heartbeat that seemed to come from everywhere at once. The portraits were awake. Several had fled their frames in alarm.

"It's coming from the walls," said Professor Brightwater, who had followed them with surprising speed for someone so old. "He is moving through the stonework, following the sound of people."

"Why is he awake?" asked Hermione.

"Because of the storm. The rain has seeped into the foundations, and the damp has loosened the old enchantments that kept him asleep."

A crack split the corridor wall with a sound like breaking ice. Pieces of plaster pattered to the floor. Through the gap came a single enormous eye, round and glowing amber, with a thousand tiny cogs spinning in its centre.

Ron let out a strangled noise. Harry gripped his wand and stepped forward.

"Don't attack," said Professor Brightwater quickly. "He is not a monster. He is frightened. Remember that."

The eye blinked slowly. Then a voice rumbled out of the wall, as deep as a cellar door opening.

"STUDENTS. OUT OF BED. DANGER. DANGER EVERYWHERE."

Harry took a deep breath. "Hello," he said gently, lowering his wand. "We're not in danger. Honestly. We're only here to talk."

Chapter 6: What the Guardian Feared

The great eye studied Harry for a long moment, and the ticking slowed by a fraction. Encouraged, Harry sat down cross-legged on the cold floor, which seemed the least threatening thing to do.

"What are you worried about?" he asked.

The Guardian's voice came in slow, grinding words. *"EVERYTHING. STAIRS. STAIRS MOVE. WINDOWS OPEN. A GIRL FELL FROM THE ASTRONOMY TOWER IN SEVENTEEN-OH-NINE. I WAS NOT THERE."*

"She was fine," said Professor Brightwater softly, stepping up beside Harry. "She floated down, you silly old thing. She grew up to be Headmistress."

"I DID NOT KNOW." The amber eye dimmed. *"I WAS INSIDE THE WALLS. I COULD NOT SEE. I COULD ONLY LISTEN. AND THERE IS SO MUCH TO LISTEN TO."*

Hermione, who had been quietly thinking, spoke up. "Harry, I don't think he needs to be stopped. I think he needs a job he can finish. Something that has an end."

"A job?" said Ron. "He's three centuries old."

"That's exactly why. He was built to protect the castle, but nobody ever told him how much protection was enough. He is stuck in a loop, worrying forever, because nobody gave him permission to stop."

Professor Brightwater's eyes widened behind her spectacles. "A limit," she whispered. "The spell had no limit. Oh, I have been a dreadful fool for three hundred years."

Chapter 7: The Spell of Enough

"Can you fix it?" asked Harry.

Professor Brightwater was already rolling her sleeves higher. "The Living Spring needs a second spell wound through the first. A spell that tells him when a task is done. But I cannot cast it alone. It needs a wizard he trusts to speak the words, and three more to hold the old magic steady while it takes hold."

Everyone looked at Harry. The Guardian's amber eye was already fixed on him.

"All right," said Harry, and he was surprised to find his voice steady. "Tell me what to say."

She taught him the words in a low whisper, a short phrase in an old, rolling Latin that felt like warm water on the tongue. Ron and Hermione stood on either side of him with their wands raised. Professor Brightwater placed both oily hands flat against the cracked wall.

"Now," she said.

Harry spoke the spell. A silver light spilled out from his wand and flowed into the crack, tracing lines through the stone like roots reaching for water. Hermione's wand shone gold and Ron's shone red, and the three colours wove together in the dark.

Inside the wall, the ticking began to change. It slowed, and softened, and for the first time in centuries it found a steady, restful rhythm.

"I," said the Guardian, in a voice that had lost its thunder, *"AM... ALLOWED TO REST?"*

"You are," said Harry. "You've done enough. You've always done enough."

Chapter 8: Morning at Hogwarts

When the silver light faded, the corridor wall was whole again, as if nothing had ever cracked it. Only a faint amber glow lingered in the stone, warm and steady like a sleeping ember.

The portraits crept back into their frames one by one, muttering. Sir Cornelius Drowse, who had slept through the entire adventure, gave an enormous snore and rolled over.

Professor Brightwater sat down on the floor, suddenly very tired, and laughed until her spectacles fell off. "Three hundred years," she said, wiping her eyes. "Three hundred years I have kept that secret down in the dark, and all he needed was a kind word and a boundary."

"That's what most people need," said Hermione wisely.

"Don't tell Fred and George," said Ron. "They'd make that into a product."

Dawn was creeping in through the corridor windows, pale and pink, and the rain had stopped at last. The three friends climbed back toward Gryffindor Tower with their shoes full of dust and their eyes heavy with sleep.

At breakfast, they were hungrier than they had ever been in their lives. Ron ate four sausages and most of a toast rack. Hermione, who never fell asleep in class, fell asleep in her porridge.

Harry looked up at the enchanted ceiling, blue and cloudless, and thought he saw, just for a moment, something glint among the high rafters. It was a tiny amber light, no larger than a candle flame.

It blinked slowly once. Then it was gone.

Chapter 9: A Gift from the Workshop

The next afternoon, a brass owl came tapping at the window of Gryffindor Tower once again. This time it carried a parcel wrapped in brown paper and tied with string.

Inside were three small, beautiful things, one for each of them. For Hermione, a silver pocket watch that never lost a minute and always chimed a gentle reminder when it was time to stop studying and go to bed. For Ron, a tin knight on a tin horse, who charged heroically across any chessboard and dented the other pieces. And for Harry, a tiny brass dragonfly that fluttered to his shoulder and whirred contentedly beside his ear.

A note was tucked in the paper, written in the same careful hand as before.

Dear Harry, Ron, and Hermione. The Guardian rests easy now, and I have found something I had not expected, which is company. Some of the creatures in my workshop have woken up, and they are quite delightful. Come visit whenever you like. The stairs will be there. Do be curious. Ottoline.

Hermione read it twice and then held the watch to her ear. "It's ticking in time with my heartbeat," she said, marvelling.

"Mine's already lost a fight with Neville's toad," said Ron, as the tin knight clattered off the windowsill. "But I like him."

Harry watched the little dragonfly circle the lamp. Outside, the sun was setting over the lake, turning the water to copper, and the whole castle seemed to hum quietly around him, safe and steady and alive.

He thought about everything in Hogwarts that was still hidden. Locked doors, forgotten rooms, old and lonely things waiting for somebody to ask them a gentle question.

Chapter 10: The Door Behind the Portrait

On Friday night, after the last lesson, the three friends slipped away from the common room again. This time they did not need the Cloak. The corridors were quiet and friendly, and the stairs, for once, stayed where they ought to.

On the third floor, Sir Cornelius Drowse was still snoring in his armchair. As they approached he cracked one blue eye open, then winked, and the portrait swung wide.

Light and music spilled up from below. It was an odd, tinkling, cheerful tune, played by a hundred clockwork instruments all slightly out of time. Professor Brightwater's laugh floated up the stairwell, and underneath it came a sound that Harry thought he recognised: a slow, deep, contented ticking, the sound of an old iron heart finally at peace.

"Do you think there are more secrets like this?" asked Ron. "In the castle?"

"I'm certain of it," said Hermione, eyes shining. "Hogwarts is full of them."

Harry smiled. He had a brass dragonfly on his shoulder, two best friends beside him, and a long staircase winding down toward a room full of warm light. He had faced darker things than this, and no doubt he would face them again. But tonight, there was only one thing left to do.

"Come on," he said, and started down the steps. "Let's go and say hello."

And the three of them went down together into the glow, while above them the old castle settled into its stones and listened, contentedly, to the quiet ticking of the night.

THE END